# Dog Chameleon

## By Eric Bogosian

*A man with suppressed anger. He tries to be pleasant.*

**MAN:** **(Pgs 81-90)** Hey, I want to be normal, just like every other guy! Don't leave me out, come on! There's got to be more to life than worrying about the price of cigarettes, getting a job, what's on TV. I know-I know about normalcy. Don't tell me about normalcy!

I want to- drive a station wagon with a bunch of kids singing Christmas carols in the backseat. I want to go to the supermarket and compare prices. I want to lose weight while I sleep. I want to buy life insurance. I want to wear pajamas and a bathrobe, sneak into the kitchen in the middle of the night and steal a drumstick out of the refrigerator. Worry about my dog's nutrition. Or maybe just order something nice from the L. L. Bean catalog. . . a nice down parka maybe, a flannel shirt. . . something in corduroy!

I know all about normalcy!

I want to yell at my wife when she goes on a spending spree! I want to help my kids with their grades! I want to fertilize my lawn. I want to order my hamburger *my way!* I want to donate money to impoverished minorities!

But all that stuff costs money. Being normal is expensive, you know?

## INTRODUCTION

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**MAN:** There was this rat scratching inside my wall the other night. After a while it sounded like it was inside my head. *And I said, "Wait a minute! Wait one minute! I'm white, I'm an American! I'm a male! I should be doing better than this!*

Ozzie and Harriet didn't have rats in the wall. There were no roaches in the Beaver's room! Even Mister Ed had *heat!* WHAT IS THIS?

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This rat kept scratching and I realized something: times have changed.

It's a race to the death now. Anyone waiting around for the good life to show up is a *fool!* Anyone who thinks that playing fair will get you anywhere is *blind!*

Then I said, “Calm down, calm down, you're getting all excited about nothing. Sure you're poor, you're an artist! You have an artistic sensibility! Artists are supposed to be poor."

I want to be rich. And I want to be famous. These are normal desires, that should not be thwarted. If you thwart them, if you repress them, you get cancer.

I want *fame!* Look at *me,* man! Fame is what counts. Fame with money. Any jerk can go-to the top of some tower with a scope rifle and start shooting at people. That's not fame. I want the good kind. The kind with lots and lots of money. Any slob can win the lottery, it takes *skill* and *brains* to get the fame and the money *at the same time.* . . that's success, man. So everyone looks at you, wherever You go, and they say, "That guy, he did it. He got everybody to look at him, admire him and give him money, their money, at the same time!"

I heard about this guy, he made four-hundred-million dollars. Four-hundred-million dollars! I'd be happy with fifty million. Most people would still think I was a success, even if I wasn't as successful as that guy. I don't care what they think! I wouldn't even tell them how much money I have! I'd just ride around in my stretch limousine, and when I got tired of that I'd go home and I'd have this enormous mansion with fifty rooms . . . And . . . and I'd have this room with a trench around it full of pit bulls, and I'd have a chair that tilts back and a TV set with remote control and a big bowl of potato chips!

And I'd just watch TV all day and change the channels. Maybe I'd just sit in a large bathtub with lots of bubbles.

I hate people. They get in the way of a good time. Just when everything's getting good, they want something from you!

But I want you all to love *me.* Even though I hate all of you. Just joking. Just joking. Don’t

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get all excited. Nothing to get excited about. Just love me. Tell me I'm great. And pay me. And then we'll be even. For all the crap you've given me my whole life! I know, I know what you're all thinking, "What a jerk. All he does is talk about himself." Yeah? And what do you do? LISTEN!

I was wronged when I was little. I never really got what I wanted. Now it's time to even the score. Even if I tell you my plans you can't stop me. I'm gonna be so rich and powerful, no one will touch me.

And all those rich creeps who lorded over me, all those muscular jocks who kicked sand in my face, all those blondies who laughed at me when I asked them for a date, all those parsimonious, paternal, patronizing administrators at school and at the unemployment office and at the IRS and the police station. . . you'll all be sorry. You have no idea what I've got in store for you. Hah!

You know what it means to be really, really rich? You walk into a store and the jerk behind the counter smirks at you because he thinks you can't afford the most expensive watch in the case. . . You know the look they give you, they humor you, "Yes sir, may I help you?"

He doesn't want to help me, he doesn't want to help anybody. Hhe just wants to laugh at me! Won't show me the watch, won't take it out, won't even tell me the price. . .

Well, when I make it, I'm going to go back to that store and I'm not going to buy one watch, I'm not going to buy ten watches-I'm going to buy the whole store, and then I'll fire that patronizing jerk for laughing at me . . . And then, I'm going to find out where he lives and I'm going to buy his apartment building and I'm going to have him evicted. . . one more pathetic homeless person walking the streets in a state of permanent depression!

Or those big thugs that push into you when you're walking down the street and don't say they're sorry or nothing. Why? Because they think I can't fight back. They think I'm afraid of them. Well, when I make it, I'm gonna get me some bodyguards. They'll walk with me when I'm going down the street. And some idiot pushes into me and I'll just step aside and there's

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my. He won't know what's hit 'im. He'll just end up on the ground, looking up at me with glazed eyes, and I'll just lean over and step over 'im and say, "Excuse me. *(Laughs)*

You think I should be ashamed of myself? I HAVE NO GUILT! Because I am not a man. I am a dog. *(barks a long howl)*

You know what I find fascinating? Human nature. The nature of human beings. . . what they like, what they don't like, what turns them on, what turns them off. What incredible appetites they have. Night after night they stay glued to their TV sets watching some pinheaded newscaster going on and on about today's news. They munch on popcorn and suck up TV dinners as they absorb the minutiae pertaining to the day's massive mud slide or exploding chemical plant.

*(Mimicking the newscaster)* ***"Thousands dead and dying! Hundreds blinded!"***

Munch. . . munch. . . "Carol, get some more salt while you're in the kitchen! . . . Oh wait, wait, come here, you have to see this-they're completely buried! Come on, you'll miss it, there's a commercial coming *on!"*

Then, these same people watch shows on educational TV about dolphins, ***then*** they cry . . . Then they stay up late to watch some old Christmas movie with Jimmy Stewart standing on a bridge on Christmas Eve; *then* they go berserk!

The next morning, they jump into their sporty compact cars, drink ten cups of coffee, and race each other on the highway while they sing along with some ardent rock singer screaming and yelling about emaciated, dark-skinned, hopeless people turning to dung half a world away.

So they feel so guilty they race home and write out a check for five dollars and mail it to some post-office box in New York City and then they feel so good about themselves, because they really, really care. . . *(pause)*

I know I'm negative. I know I'm not a nice guy. I know you all hate me. But I don't care.

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Because at least I realize I'm a bad person, and for that tiny fragment of truth, I respect myself. That's why normalcy is so far out of my reach. Because you have to be blind to be normal. You have to like yourself, and the thought of that is so repellent to me that I'm ecstatic to be in the depressing place that I am!

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Eric Bogosian***
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## AWARD HISTORY

***MN State Qualifier***

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